offices of the Ministry of External Affairs by a small door. ‘If the door is open,’ Singh observed, ‘they are working closely together. If the door is closed they are not.’[14] As prime minister, Nehru used that door frequently as he was his own foreign minister. The door continues to be used but the frequency with which foreign ministry officials can access the PMO, or vice versa, through that door has come to symbolize the extent of cooperation between the two bureaucracies.

In some ways, interaction between the Indian chief executive’s political team and the cadres of permanent state functionaries resembles the relationship between 10, Downing Street and Whitehall in Britain. India’s adaptation of the Westminster model was heavily influenced by the towering personality of Nehru, who led India as prime minister for seventeen formative years. Nehru overshadowed his cabinet, the parliament and the permanent bureaucracy. He also saw himself as his own best civil servant. Impatient by nature, Nehru often took decisions on his own and even sent replies to diplomatic cables.

Nehru’s passion for and interest in foreign affairs meant that by the time he became prime minister he had rather firm views on international affairs. Other leaders of the Indian independence movement paid much less attention to foreign affairs than Nehru. Although he consulted some of his top officials, Nehru tended to make decisions on the basis of his own knowledge and instincts. According to Jayantanuja Bandyopadhyaya, who served in the Indian Foreign Service for several years, the advisory role of the missions and the foreign office under Nehru was minimal for two reasons. The first of these was Nehru’s belief that he seldom needed advice. The second, and more significant, was the fact that Indian foreign policy was still being crafted in the early years of Independence and dealt more with ‘broad generalities and problems of international relations rather than with detailed and specific problems’ requiring an Indian response.[15]